



PRESIDENT PRATIBHA PATIL, PRIME MINISTER MANMOHAN SINGH AND SPEAKER MEIRA KUMAR WALK TOWARDS CENTRAL HALL OF PARLIAMENT

SIPRA DAS

DELHI

House of Hope

It's payback time. The President's address during the first session of the 15th Lok Sabha reinforced all the manifesto promises made by the Congress-led UPA. Pratibha Patil talked about consolidating the flagship programmes of the UPA Government and often echoed the prime minister's favourite catchphrase—inclusive growth. A strong mandate credited to the Government's social development schemes has now given the UPA further muscle to take on the controversial issues of pension reforms and public sector disinvestment. If the PMO believed it had banished the bogey of the Left, a swift rethink was in order. Speaking during the debate in the Rajya Sabha, DMK chief Karunanidhi's daughter Kanimozhi argued that divesting PSUs "will not help," especially in India, where she said "the socialist model was very important". The Trinamool Congress's Mamata Banerjee is also believed to be against the indiscriminate disinvestment of PSUs. "The speech reflects the views of the government in the context of the mandate it has received," said Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee, whose budget is bound to be the UPA's next big policy statement. But is the UPA ready for its new Left within? There seems to be not a whiff of doubt as optimism is in the air. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh declared, "If all of us work together, we can achieve a growth rate of 8 to 9 per cent even if the world economy does not do well." And so the new government kicks off on a note of both high growth and high hope, with even Leader of the Opposition L.K. Advani saying, "Let the Government do its duty and the NDA will do its."

by Priya Sahgal

8-9

per cent GDP growth is what Prime Minister Manmohan Singh says India can achieve despite the economic slowdown.